

Comprehensive CDC Positive Parenting Protocols

Structured Action-Response Pairs for RAG Ingestion (Ages 0 to 15+ Years)

Category: Infants (0-1 Year)

[Tags: infant, crying, soothing, emotional regulation]

Child Action: The infant cries inconsolably despite being fed and having a clean diaper.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Assess:** Check for signs of illness or physical discomfort (e.g., fever, tight clothing).
2. **Regulate Self:** Take a deep breath. A calm parent helps calm the baby.
3. **Soothe:** Rock the baby gently, sing softly, or use skin-to-skin contact.
4. **Safe Space:** If frustration peaks, place the baby in a safe crib, step out of the room for 1 minute to regroup, then return.

[Tags: act early, infant, developmental delay, social interaction]

Child Action (Milestone Check): The infant is 6 months old and does not smile back or show affection for caregivers.

Act Early Protocol:

1. **Document:** Note the specific lack of response during play or feeding.
2. **Consult:** Share this observation with the pediatrician at the next well-child visit.
3. **Intervene:** Increase face-to-face interaction. Do not wait to see if the child "grows out of it."

Category: Toddlers (1-3 Years)

[Tags: toddler, boundary testing, defiance, safety]

Child Action: The toddler runs toward the street or touches something dangerous.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Intervene Immediately:** Physically stop the child from the dangerous action.
2. **Set Boundary (Firmly):** State clearly, "No. The street is dangerous. We hold hands."
3. **Redirect:** Move the child to a safe area or offer a safe alternative activity.

[Tags: toddler, tantrums, emotional outburst, transition]

Child Action: The toddler throws a tantrum because it is time to leave the park.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Acknowledge Emotion:** "You are very angry because you want to keep playing."
2. **Hold the Limit:** "But it is time to go home and eat dinner."
3. **Offer Limited Choice:** "Do you want to hop like a bunny to the car, or should I carry you?"
4. **Follow Through:** If they refuse the choice, gently pick them up and proceed without negotiating.

Category: Preschoolers (3-5 Years)

[Tags: preschooler, sibling conflict, aggression]

Child Action: The child hits a sibling or snatches a toy.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Separate & Assess:** Separate the children immediately. Check the hit child for injury.
2. **Identify Rule:** "We do not hit. Hitting hurts."
3. **Enforce Consequence:** "Because you hit, the toy goes in time-out for 5 minutes."
4. **Teach Alternative:** "Next time, say 'My turn please' or come ask me for help."

Category: School-Age Children (6-14 Years)

[Tags: school-age, defiance, homework, responsibility]

Child Action: The child refuses to do their homework or complete assigned household chores.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Validate & Investigate:** Ask calmly, "I see you're avoiding your homework. Are you feeling overwhelmed by it?"
2. **Break it Down:** Offer to help them break the task into smaller, manageable 15-minute chunks.
3. **Enforce Logical Consequence:** "Homework needs to be done before screen time. You can choose to do it now, or miss your game time later."

[Tags: act early, school-age, bullying, school avoidance]

Child Action (Social/Emotional Check): The child fakes illness frequently to avoid school or comes home with unexplained missing items or bruises.

Act Early Protocol:

1. **Open Dialogue:** Ask open-ended questions like, "Who did you sit with at lunch today?" rather than "Are you being bullied?"
2. **Validate Safety:** Assure them it is not their fault and they are safe discussing it with you.
3. **Escalate:** Contact the child's teacher or school counselor privately to investigate the social dynamics at school.

Category: Adolescence (15+ Years)

[Tags: adolescence, peer pressure, risky behavior, communication]

Child Action: The teen is pressured to engage in risky behavior (e.g., drug use, drinking, or getting a ride from an impaired driver).

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Plan Ahead:** Proactively establish an "exit plan" or code word the teen can text to be picked up immediately, no questions asked in the moment.
2. **Support Safely:** If they call for help, pick them up calmly without immediate anger or punishment.
3. **Discuss & Advise:** The next day, ask open-ended questions. Listen without playing down their concerns, and answer honestly.

[Tags: adolescence, boundary testing, curfew, responsibility]

Child Action: The teen violates a mutual household rule, such as missing curfew.

Approved Parent Response Protocol:

1. **Regulate & Listen:** Stay calm. Ask them to explain their reasoning for the choice and listen respectfully.
2. **Shift to Advising:** Ask, "What do you think the consequences of this choice should be?" to build their critical reasoning skills.
3. **Enforce Logical Consequence:** Apply a relevant, pre-established consequence (e.g., an earlier curfew the next weekend).